originally dominated by men from the *kibbutzim* and the Labor movement. They played a disproportionately large role even into the 1980s, with Labor out of power and the army embroiled in a controversial war in Lebanon. Back then, more than 25 per cent of army officers (and a similar share of air force pilots, another "elite" group) were kibbutzniks, at a time when they represented just 3 per cent of the Israeli population.

Rabin was the most famous example, but equally influential was Amnon Lipkin-Shahak, a fellow paratrooper and a longtime friend of the slain prime minister. He enlisted in the army in 1962. When he finished his military career thirty-six years later, he was the chief of staff; he then joined the Labor party for a brief stint in the Knesset. As a man respected by both the Israeli public and the Palestinian leadership, he played a major role in negotiating the Oslo Accords. In 1994, when the massacre at the Ibrahimi Mosque in Hebron threatened to derail peace talks, the prime minister dispatched Lipkin-Shahak to Tunis to meet with Yasser Arafat, the Palestinian leader. "Arafat so trusted Amnon… that he agreed to return to negotiations without demanding any compensation," Martin Indyk, the former US ambassador to Israel, wrote decades later.[5]

His views put him at odds with Netanyahu, the head of Likud, who was a fierce critic of both Rabin and the Oslo process. Netanyahu won the early election called in 1996, in the wake of Rabin's assassination, and quickly set about trying to undo his predecessor's efforts at peace. The climax came in September, when he and Ehud Olmert (then the mayor of Jerusalem) agreed to open a previously restricted part of the tunnels underneath the Temple Mount and Al-Aqsa Mosque. His security officials had warned that the move—like any changes in the Old City—would lead to Palestinian riots. Indeed, Rabin had considered the same proposal, but decided not to do it, according to his longtime aide, Eitan Haber. "We waited thousands of years, said Yitzhak Rabin, and we will wait a few more," he wrote in *Yediot Aharonot* after the riots. But Netanyahu went ahead anyway, to demonstrate Israel's "sovereignty over Jerusalem" to his right-wing base.

The security chiefs were correct. More than a hundred people died in the ensuing violence. Netanyahu rejected any criticism of his decision, however, and blamed the riots on Arafat. "We're in a peace process, not in a process where anyone can come and say, 'oh dear, I feel like shooting at Israeli forces,'" he said sarcastically at a news conference on the third day of unrest.[6]